

Blue Moon

What have you done?

She was never a morning person. Every day, her alarm reminded her of the ungodly hour she was meant to wake up at, totally prepared for anything. She rarely was, however, as Milana continued to shuffle in her bed against the moon's waning rays. At the sound of her third alarm—and the pervasive sun inviting itself into her room—Milana finally found the strength to get moving.

She grappled with her wardrobe for a bit, never quite satisfied with what it had to offer before making her way downstairs to the kitchen. Milana's mom was already pouring her daily glass of orange juice when Milana entered and beelined to the pantry. Down in a smooth swig, Milana's mom finished the OJ and turned to her daughter, "Morning, *dolcezza*. I'm about off to work. Make sure to take out the trash when you get home from school. Also, your brother should be home from your dad's on Sunday. Could you pick him up for me?"

Milana nodded groggily while retrieving a bowl from the cabinet and listened to her mom as she continued.

"Alright, I'm—oh! One more thing: I'm going to be home pretty late tonight. The proposal is final today and the guys wanna go out for drinks to celebrate. Who knows, maybe I'll even score with Brian," she winked with extra enthusiasm to which Milana rolled her eyes, earning herself a kiss on the forehead. Milana swiped away the red lipstick mark on her temple and watched as her mom fled out the door.

No matter how hard she scrubs, it won't come off. Her leg is probably pink from the force of her hand—she doesn't know, though, since it's covered in a mix of dirt and blood. Not that she can see either. The trees above her shield the gleam of the moon, allowing solely shards of

scattered light to peer subtly through the leaves. That and her eyes are flooded with red. They move, but they see little. Only the faded blue concrete of the desolate tennis court and the immobile length of a body next to the torn net.

The rickety old beetle stuttered to a stop in the parking lot, causing a handful of students to glance over in awkward awe. Milana made a mental note that *this* week was the week it'd go to the shop before hopping out and slamming the door shut at just the right angle. Not even a few seconds into her walk, an arm wrapped around Milana's neck and pulled her tight to the side of the other body.

"Ok, I know you don't want to hear this, but Jordan actually apologized this time anddd we sort of got back together."

Milana sighed and stared at Kiera in disappointment, "I thought we agreed you'd drop him for good?"

"Well—! I mean, yeah, but we chatted and...one thing led to another..." Kiera trailed off.

Milana didn't want to entertain this conversation at 8 AM, so she held her peace.

Kiera picked back up, "Ugh whatever. Don't judge me! Anyways, I gotta get to calc. Thought I'd give you a quick life update, but you hate me so nevermind."

Milana rolled her eyes as Kiera continued, "Before I go, I'm having a little kickback tonight that you should definitely pop out to."

Milana was about to start before Kiera shoved a finger in her face and interrupted, "And don't give me that nonsense with your mom. You *have* to come. Especially since *he* 'll be there."

Before Milana could even muster up a reaction, Kiera was giggling into the distance. So, instead, she shook her head and pulled open the school doors.

Ripping her hair out won't solve her issues, but the notion isn't any less tempting even with that in mind. Though the landscape around her isn't in the brightest light, his body seems to radiate vibrance, almost saying "Hey! Come look at what she did to me!" She wishes to shut it up.

Her lungs gyrate in an awkward tempo, closing her throat from any access to air. Hiccuffed gasps escape her mouth as she tries to regain control of her breathing and brokenly jittered fingers scrape against the pavement in sorrowful attempts at release. She can only stare up at the sky, trying to piece together the fragmented moon across the jagged treeline with tears misting the view into one big checkered blob. In a miniscule amount of stability, she narrows her view on his body. Blocking his face is a chunk of concrete, blood now spattered over the displaced blue of the court. His frame is smooshed in unnatural ways; dents follow his torso up to his head while his legs remain ultimately unharmed save a few knee scrapes. The largest dent lay on his temple and if she were to prod at it, she'd surely relate the texture to that of mashed potatoes. Her observations bring bile to the back of her throat, so she turns away and focuses on the twinge in her leg that's been throbbing with each passing second.

The halls echoed Milana's footsteps, completely disregarding her trial tiptoeing. If anything, her gentle steps reverberated louder than her normal ones, so she gave up. Swinging the hall pass in hand, Milana turned the corner and walked at a relaxed speed to the restroom at the end of the hallway. She wasn't in a hurry to get back to English, so she decided to stop at one of the GoHealthy vending machines and browse its options.

"Just a bunch of junk, huh?" Milana mumbled to herself, then reluctantly picked out a peanut butter protein bar to stash in her pocket for later.

As Milana moved toward the bathroom, she was halted by the presence of a motionless figure across the hall. It didn't take long for her cheeks to flush in recognition of the person. It was **him**. Isaac's face—his eyes—was one she could recognize from a mile away. There was a certain occupancy about his eyes that forced those they laid upon to stand sharply stagnant until their scrutiny ceased. In her case, they stripped her form, keeping her in a commanded state of mental disarray. She was so nervous under the critique of his crystalline eyes—the deep, visceral blue inspired several tumultuous feelings inside her stomach. And, when paired with the slight upturn of his lips, she couldn't help but freeze like a deer in the headlights.

She didn't know whether she should wave or not, but they'd been standing there for so long—or, as long as it had been, time didn't seem to exist then—it'd be weird to suddenly wave. Maybe she'd been overthinking it, though, because, in the next second, he swiftly disappeared from the hallway and out of her line of sight. The breath she'd been unknowingly holding stumbled from her lungs upon his departure, followed by a series of flippant hand gestures and jaw exercises. It's as if Milana had been put on pause, then suddenly played again—back to her regular schedule. And that she did, clamoring toward the bathroom with a stronger pep in her step from before. This time, the protruding clock from the ceiling joined the symphony of the hushed hall, heartily counting down the minutes in alignment with her footsteps.

Because of her ticking leg, pulling him is her only escape. She can't lift him—every raise of his torso runs a blistering needle down to her ankle. She tries to situate his body against the fence, but it just slumps into itself and topples over. Even when she pulls him, her leg never ceases its karmic splintering, though the pulling motion supports her leg better there than any other movement. It also doesn't help that she's blatantly too weak to carry his burly body. The chatter of the birds above chastises her brittle bones. She isn't going to give in. She tells herself

if she goes slow, she'll get somewhere. Eventually, she situates her arms under his armpits, and—leaning primarily on her good leg—manages to drag him out of the court.

Graphite cats littered the page, some with pointy ears, others with long whiskers, embodied or disembodied, they permeated the faint blue lines.

“...Natural disasters have many impacts on the world around them. They're devastating events that not only affect our lives but also the lives of species living in the destroyed areas...”

The most information that had stuck to Milana's paper was “Unit 5”—the cats had eaten the rest of it. With a slight tilt of her head, Milana saw the way the trees swayed as a breeze brushed through their outreaching arms. A squirrel climbed up the side of one of the trees, possessively holding an acorn between its jaws. It seemed to be having more fun than she.

“...Chain events can occur, mainly caused by the severity of global warming and climate change. For example, typhoons have increased because of rising sea levels which are caused...”

Blanketing the landscape, the blue sky was dotted with cotton-ball clouds. Oh, how Milana wished she could bounce around in their fluffy enclosure, take a chunk out of it and melt it down in her mouth. Nestled behind a bundle of clouds was the moon, just barely visible, but still there. It was tiny and bore a penny sized dot into the sky when Milana closed one eye and circled her fingers around it like a telescope. If she looked close enough, she could see the man in the moon wearing his permanent shocked expression. She wondered what could have brought him such a fright.

“...anyone tell me why hurricanes are more likely to occur across the equator? No one? Come on guys, this is on your test...”

Milana could no longer ignore the eyes that had been burrowing into her back since she sat down. She knew who they belonged to, but she couldn't turn around because that would draw

abundant unneeded attention to herself. She could've passed a note to him, but who was to say the note ever reached his desk? What would she have even said? She was too chicken to initiate any kind of interaction with him, so maybe this was her punishment. She should've sat behind him on the first day so she wouldn't have to endure this. It was his fault for coming in late. His cough brought her down to reality and her attention back to his gaze. It itched her neck—made her squirm—so, to distract herself, she went back to the cats.

“...On average, forest fires spread at about 14 miles per hour. Coupled with this speed, they can reach temperatures of over 1,000 degrees Fahrenheit! That's a mighty hot sauna if you ask me...”

With each finger she presses to his collarbone, dragging him through the pitch-black void of the forest, she is met with fire. His body doesn't drop to an icicle like the movies—it breathes, almost like a headless chicken. She wishes to rid her limbs of its contact, but it's futile. She can feel the itch of his skin wanting to merge with hers and take it for his own. It pulses, cries, and scorns her; she can't escape her own evil, so she should just give her body to it—to him. It's so alive it strikes her soul. Is he alive?

Milana bounced between her computer and textbook, transcribing whatever she read into her history assignment. The urge to pull out her earbuds and listen to music was intense, but she resisted because she knew the librarians would have a fit. Ever since Greg Muller fell asleep with his headphones in between the nonfiction A-E aisles, leading to his overnight library entrapment, every kind of music device had been banned. Milana could still do her work, of course, but she would forever miss her music-filled study blocks.

A clamor came from the front of the library, and when Milana craned her head to look, her heart jumped. There was a group of boys at the entrance being chewed out by one of the

librarians and at the very front of the pack was Isaac. Probably sensing her creepy gaze, Isaac looked directly at Milana, his stark blue eyes holding her own captive. And, within a few seconds, or what felt like it, after waving off his friends, he stood at her table. They stared in silence for a moment; then, when Milana started darting her gaze to anywhere that wasn't him, Isaac placed his hand on her shoulder and squeezed, pointedly directing her to his eyes—his hypnotic blue eyes.

“Hey,” he said after she was stunned into silence.

She replied with a beat, “Hi.”

“So, you coming?”

She stared at him, a slight crease in her brow at what he meant.

He clarified, “To Kiera’s thing.”

“Oh! Uh...” she hesitated, but after seeing his expectant gaze, she blurted, “yeah!”

“Cool. See you then,” he smiled, then walked off to join his friends.

I'm a good person.

It was nice to feel the chilling breeze on her goosebumped skin—it reminded her that school was in fact over and she withstood another day of environmental science. However, it also brought another challenge: what was she going to say to her mom? Milana fiddled with her phone as lowerclassmen rushed past her to the bus loop. Her mom’s picture stared at her in their text chat, the last chat reading *Let me know if anything happens!* Disparagingly ironic, but it didn’t stop Milana from switching to Kiera’s text chat and sending her a quick *I’ll be there*. Milana slid her already vibrating phone into her back pocket, somewhat afraid if she held onto it any longer, she’d backtrack. Her gaze found the sky, resting on the moon to comfort her quarrel. Its shimmer seemed more present as the day had tired and prepared to tuck itself into the horizon.

Turning away, she nearly missed the step off the sidewalk into the parking lot, but she hopped swiftly at the last second in recovery and made her way to her car.

She doesn't anticipate the hill down to the base of the lake to approach her so fast, but it does, and it sends her flying backward after one misplaced step on a leaf-covered log. Bouncing around like a ball in a pinball machine, her torso is clipped by a root before she hits the bottom of the hill. It aches as she dazedly sits up and hugs her ribs, probably more tightly than necessary. She doesn't have time to recover, though, because she finds a pair of hands scraping their way up her legs. One hand inches up her shirt to ride it over her stomach while she sits sublimely statuesque. Another throws itself into her jeans and down her thigh. His body comes into view, thus bringing his head with it as all press closer. He's facing her, but she can't see it—the face. No, not that she can't see it, there just isn't one to be seen. It's blank, a fleshy canvas ready for her fingers to carve into. And, they do. She rips at it, sinking her arm into his face to reach for his brain, going deeper to twirl his stomach, grabbing—

A car alarm rings out in the distance. She sucks in a breath and coughs a bit, inadvertently churning her uneasy torso. Her eyes dart around and eventually find him lying face down across her feet with his right arm tweaked in the wrong direction.

Milana's closet wasn't giving her much to work with. Everything in it was something she had bought or picked out, yet there was nothing to wear. She felt a skirt would be too classy, a t-shirt would be too sloppy, jeans would be too boring, and a dress would be too out of place. She was going to a simple kickback, not a movie premiere. Defeated, she grumbled to her bathroom and splashed water on her face with the hope that it would magically open her perspective and find her the perfect outfit.

Water pools her cheeks, her tears steadily melting the dirt and blood that gunk up her face. At every tweet of a bird and rustle of a leaf, she searches for the source. The forest is closing in on her, and no matter how desperately she tries to pick up her pace, his body won't allow it. With each step, her foot slams to the ground and cracks the sticks beneath her. The crunching grows louder and clunkier and when she looks down, she doesn't see sticks. Bones flood the forest floor, at first still, then clanging. Circling her feet, they all rattle toward her. She watches as the bones clasp to her legs, hurriedly sprinting up her body, and—no, they're just sticks.

She wiped her nerves onto her jeans as she stood on the familiar stoop of her best friend. Milana hesitated with the doorbell, straightened her black long-sleeve, and, after a minute, shoved her finger into the button. The door stayed closed for a while which led Milana to build up her courage and ring a second time. She was starting to deliberate going to the backyard where faint music played, but eventually, the door swung open with a beaming Kiera behind it.

“Milana! Come in come in, you're finally here,” Kiera exclaimed, ushering Milana into the large house before closing the door behind her.

“Drinks are in the kitchen and everyone's out back. I got your favorite seltzers too. You *are* drinking, right?”

Milana nodded, “Yeah, I walked. I told you I would.”

“Yeah, but I don't want you to walk home drunk. You can stay over, you know?”

“I know, but I have to get home before my mom gets back. I'm on a time crunch,” Milana sighed.

Frowning, Kiera picked up a few beers and led Milana out the back door, “Alright, Cinderella. Whatever you say.”

Kiera walked off and handed the beers to a pair leaning on the railing of her porch. Milana, having taken a peach seltzer from the kitchen, cracked her drink open and slowly made her way down to the grass. She was approaching a few people she recognized when Isaac came into view. The moon practically shone a spotlight on his body, purposefully drawing Milana's eyes to his incandescence. He was chatting animatedly with a different group near the dock, then went to sip his drink, but stopped when he saw Milana. Despite their distance, his eyes were clear as day in her sight. The radiant blue was that of the Caribbean Ocean once it blended into the deep sea. His eyes swam down her figure ever so slowly and threatened to stop time altogether. She could've drowned in them.

The blue of the water forces a chilling sensation down her spine. With the lake in full view, she sees the waves pulse along the shoreline, beckoning her to come closer. Each tug of his body foretells the failure of her leg, but she continues her pursuit. It isn't *he* who fuels her drive; it's the lake. The lake and its mirrored moon glistening in abstract when a small wave bubbles up. The moon can scarcely be seen through the trees, but across the water, it's clear. The white surface burns its image into the iridescent layer of the current and throws speckled light into the depth of the forest. In some capacity, it's beautiful. But then, she's back to lugging that pale body toward the moon. She feels sorry for the blemish she will put on its darling face.

"Wait, I *totally* thought you were gay."

"Huh?! Pfft, no, why does *everyone* think that?!"

The squabbling voices of two boys enticed Milana to take a lengthy swig of her drink, thus spreading a bubbling grape sensation through her gums. The boys cackled outwardly with each other and stumbled over as Milana took the chance to look at Isaac. He was already staring at her, causing her to flush and take another sip of her seltzer. It took all the liquid courage

staining her veins to hobble over to him, her mind racing the whole time over how to keep her cool. When she finally placed herself in front of him, she lost all her words. In a wave of panic, she opted for a grubby hand gesture.

“Hey,” he said in a languid tone.

After reminding herself how to articulate sentences, she replied, “Hi.”

“How’re you liking it? The party?”

“Oh, ya’know. It’s a party.”

He sniffed out a laugh, “That’s true.”

Milana shuffled her feet, unsure of how to continue their conversation before he piped up once more.

“What’re you drinking?”

She raised her seltzer and read from the label, “‘Grape Burst.’ What about you?”

“Just water for me. I’m driving home.”

With a hum, she licked the excess liquid from the lid of her drink and took a strong swig, finishing the can off. Before she could swallow, she felt a touch to the side of her stomach. One finger managed its way under her shirt, and she could tell he was about to say something, but he was cut off when a guy in his underwear came running through the crowded backyard screaming at the top of his lungs. Milana watched in awe as the guy soared off the dock into the lake, closely followed by a few others. It didn’t take long for the whole expanse of the party to dress down to their underwear and dash towards the lake. Kiera was about to run past Milana when she grabbed her arm and stopped her from doing so.

“What’s going on?” Milana asked frantically.

Kiera laughed and grabbed Milana's arm, pulling her towards the dock, "Come on, Milana! Jump in!"

"Wait, what?"

She garnered no reply as Kiera continued to urge Milana closer to the water. When they hit the sturdy wood of the dock, Milana spun her head around to find the boy she had promptly left behind. His unmoving figure stood out against the migrating masses; he just looked at her, a cheesy grin spanning his face as he began to take his shirt off. The last thing she saw was his hands slipping under his belt buckle before she plummeted into the teen-infested waters below.

His body hits the lake with a burly umph, the *true* reality of her situation setting in when the frigid water engulfs her ankles. He isn't fully submerged—not even remotely—so she walks down the ledge, dragging his body by the arm—the good arm—until she can barely touch the bottom. When spews of lake water invade her mouth and nose as she tries to stay afloat, she knows she can't go any further. She lunges his body downward in harsh, sporadic pumps. But, unsurprisingly, despite her desperation, he steadily rises to the surface with a trail of bubbles following. She dunks him again, throwing her body weight onto his, but to no avail. His tranquil bobs in the water taunt her—she'll never get rid of him. Ignoring her thoughts, she rips his body to an area where she has more footing and continuously shakes him in the shallow water. With each wake created, he remains surfaced, floating as the moon encapsulates him in an enchanting halo. Her body vibrates to insanity and disposes of tears to drip in rippled tides. Her leg hurts. She wishes she were dead. She screams at him to stay down for good. She kneels in the water, just wading; small waves bring his head to bump her arm.

After some time, she takes him to the shore and lets him rock in the shallows while she sits in the chilled sand. Sinking her toes into the mineralized ground, she watches his butchered

body bleed across the moon, its face tainted and swirling with red rivers. Right next to this is the reflection of some kind of sculpture. She turns her head but doesn't see a sculpture; instead, she sees a boat.

The music guided Milana's limbs in a slurred performance of flawed freedom. Drinks gone and mixing in her stomach to brew an innocuous potion of haziness, Milana felt bubbly. She and a few other nameless faces danced completely out of tempo in a sloppy, soggy formation to a lullaby-like song. Suddenly, a pair of hands slithered around Milana's waist and spun her body to face theirs. Her head fell back at the speed of the spin and forced her arms to stabilize themselves on the chest in front of her. She didn't need to look to know who it was. Her butterflies died when his hands found their way around different parts of her body. One hand groped at her ass, causing her heart to drop and her mouth to go dry. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw the nameless faces giggle off into the house and take turns sneaking peeks at her ensnarement. They could be heard remarking the pair in giddy, jealousy, disgust—no matter, their muffled squeals and groans only wrung her with dread and bloated him with persistence before the deck door closed behind them, leaving the pair alone under the watch of the night sky.

She felt like fly in a web—if she moved, he would tighten his hold on her. His hands moved in rhythm with the cheerful laughs inside. When the wind picked up, her shiver under his touch brought scathing nausea to her throat. Everytime his arm shifted, she could see the reflective moonlight change position. She felt shameful standing under such a gorgeous moon on such a gorgeous night wishing she were anywhere else but here. The sensation of his fingers imprinting her belly snapped her head to the house in a muted plea for notice.

With a sharp crack of his palm on her jaw, he whispered down her neck, “Not them. Only me.”

His voice reminded her of her own, so she tried, “Stop.”

It went unnoticed. Or, ignored. She didn’t know. She knew his hands pushed forward. She knew her choked sob died before it could reach the house.

An attempt at pushing his chest off her own left her with more pressure and a snakey fondling of her boob. Her head fell back upon these vertiginous movements and left her to stare at his face. He wasn’t looking at her. Moreso, he *wouldn’t* look at her. She bore her gaze into his downturned forehead, and for a minute, she thought he’d never look up. But, he did. His expression was mercilessly serious. The blue of his eyes casted a shadow onto his pupils and raged like a tropical storm. Their fierceness submerged her every muscle and plagued her with fatigue. She *was* drowning.

And suddenly, they were gone. His forehead occupied her view once more as his hands continued to grip at her skin. She knew she was crying, and he probably did too, but little was done to prevent it. He continued, crawling further and further down till he reached the inside of her thigh—

A loud crash and various whoops from inside the house broke the air outside, distracting Isaac long enough for Milana to regain her strength, push him off her, and speed-walk towards the back door.

The urgency of her rowing has successfully landed her in the middle of the lake. She takes a moment to breathe and let her beaten body recover. But, no sooner does she stop than she stands up to finish what she started. The old boat shifts from side to side at each movement, but after she has substantially settled its shaking, she lugs him up and dangles him off the side of the boat. His body hangs like a wooden puppet with his joints falling out of whack and his arms swinging back and forth, grazing the top of the water with each sway. She musters all her

strength to haul his body over the edge of the boat, his form carrying on a few extra pounds with the rocks she has tied to his chest; nevertheless, she manages to toss him into the lake without tipping over. Plopping down on the old, decaying bench, she watches as he sinks into the depths of the water. Right before he disappears, his eyes open and capture her own, forcing her to see him in all his glory. As the rest of his body fades away, blending into the murky abyss, the prominent blue of his eyes lingers, almost illuminating the darkness he's fading into. Then, an overcast of red conceals the eyes, leaving her to swipe away the image with a quick splash of her hand.

Her feet pounded as she walked along the edge of the road. Kiera's bright name shining across her phone screen brought a winced frown to Milana's face. *are u good? sure u dont wanna stay longer?* Her text garnered no reply for a while, but Milana finally wiped her tears and bit the bullet with the response *yeah im good*. Shoving her phone into her back pocket, Milana focused her eyes on the road ahead and the distant abandoned tennis court that marked the halfway point to her house. The wind that had been howling the whole walk home finally paused and allowed for Milana's damp, sobered-up body to cease its shivering. However, the absence of its screech invited a new sound to her senses: a very light pair of footsteps out of pace with her own. Milana sped up her walk which elicited the same reaction from the disembodied steps. When she had made it to the entrance of the tennis court, she stopped, as did the other. A moment passed, then she whipped around in hopes of catching a glimpse of the owner of the footsteps.

He stood in the shadows, his silhouette being the one visible thing about him. That, and his eyes. His painful blue eyes that dropped her stomach. His eyes that defined her life for the greater part of her high school years. His eyes that reflected the moon when seen at just the right angle. His eyes that swamped her view until they swallowed her whole.